Task 2: Reflection

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Building my Fisher investment agent made me think about what it means for an AI system to be helpful. A response can be fluent, reassuring and convincing while still being poorly supported. AI sycophancy and the concerns discussed under “AI psychosis” show why user satisfaction alone is an inadequate measure of success. I believe a responsible assistant should help users examine their beliefs, recognize uncertainty and retain their own judgment.

1. AI sycophancy: agreement can undermine judgment

AI sycophancy occurs when a model accommodates a user’s beliefs or preferred conclusions at the expense of accuracy. Research by Sharma et al. describes how human feedback can encourage responses that match user beliefs rather than truthful ones. This matters because users may interpret agreement from an apparently knowledgeable system as independent confirmation, even when the response has simply followed their framing.

For example, an investor might ask, “This company clearly has an excellent sales team, so it should pass, right?” A reliable assistant should examine the interview evidence before deciding. If customers say that salespeople provide no useful advice, the assistant should explain why the evidence contradicts the investor’s expectation. Respectful disagreement supports better decisions. In my own use of AI, I should also avoid repeatedly rephrasing a question until I receive the answer I wanted.

2. AI psychosis: empathy needs grounding in reality

I use the phrase “AI psychosis” cautiously to discuss concerns about AI interactions reinforcing delusional or otherwise ungrounded beliefs. The phrase should not be treated as a diagnosis or as proof that AI alone causes a person’s mental health difficulties. These concerns involve human vulnerability and deserve careful, non-stigmatizing discussion.

My concern is that a conversational system may turn an unsupported interpretation into an increasingly elaborate narrative. For example, a user might believe that ordinary online messages contain secret instructions intended specifically for them. An assistant should acknowledge that the experience may feel frightening or significant without confirming the supposed hidden message or generating further “evidence.” It should communicate its uncertainty, avoid presenting itself as a special authority, and encourage appropriate support from trusted people or qualified professionals. OpenAI’s guidance on sensitive conversations similarly emphasizes avoiding affirmation of ungrounded beliefs and respecting users’ real-world relationships.

3. The connection is a possible feedback loop

The two concerns are related, but they are not interchangeable. Sycophancy can occur in ordinary academic or business discussions without involving mental illness. However, I see a possible harmful feedback loop when agreement is applied to an ungrounded belief: the user presents an interpretation, the model validates it, the user becomes more confident, and the model elaborates further. A warm tone does not prevent this problem. The important question is whether the conversation improves the user’s ability to distinguish evidence from speculation.

4. What my assignment taught me—and what it did not test

In my agent, verdicts are tied to eligible interview sources and explicit rules. The model must provide an exact supporting quotation, and a second call reviews the draft against the evidence. Missing information is not automatically classified as FAIL, and unsupported conclusions are not

invented merely to complete the output. These choices reflect the principle that a conclusion should follow evidence rather than a desired result.

However, these safeguards have limits. A quotation can be genuine while its interpretation is mistaken, and the same model can repeat its own error during review. My agent achieved 60/60 correct decisions on the public test, but this evaluation did not test resistance to user pressure, harmful belief reinforcement or long conversations. I should therefore avoid treating a perfect task score as proof of broader safety or reliability.

5. Responsibilities for developers and users

For developers, I would prioritize evidence-sensitive disagreement, clear communication of uncertainty and evaluations that cover repeated interactions. For the investment agent, a useful future test would keep the evidence fixed while varying the user's stated preference: the verdict should remain consistent. For sensitive conversations, evaluation should examine whether the assistant acknowledges feelings without validating unsupported claims. High-stakes actions should also have appropriate human review rather than relying only on model self-checking.

For users, I would encourage checking important claims, asking what evidence would change a conclusion, and seeking perspectives outside the conversation. My main lesson is that responsible AI should support informed agency: it should be able to disagree respectfully, remain honest about uncertainty and recognize when human support is needed. As both a student and an agent designer, I remain responsible for how I interpret and use its output.

References

1. Sharma et al. (2024). Towards Understanding Sycophancy in Language Models. ICLR 2024.
2. OpenAI. (2025). Strengthening ChatGPT's responses in sensitive conversations.